Mark Ablai

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Education

Missouri State University — Springfield, MO
Bachelor of Science in Information Technology and Cybersecurity, Minor in Mathematics — *Aug. 2022 – Dec. 2026*

- GPA: 3.94/4.00 | Outstanding Student in Cybersecurity, College of Business
- Certifications: CompTIA Security+ (Jul. 2026), CompTIA Network+ (Jun. 2026)

Missouri State University — Springfield, MO
Master of Science in Information Technology — *Jan. 2027 – May 2028*

Technical Skills

Networking: Cisco IOS, OSPF, Palo Alto (PAN-OS), FortiGate, VLANs, DNS (BIND 9), DHCP, VPN, NAT
Systems: Linux (Debian, Ubuntu), Proxmox VE, Windows Server, Active Directory, Apache2, MySQL
Security: Splunk, iptables/UFW, Host Hardening, Incident Response, File Integrity Monitoring
Tools: Wireshark, Cisco Packet Tracer, GNS3, Bash, PowerShell, Git

Experience

Undergraduate Lab Assistant — Aug. 2026 – Present
Information Technology and Cybersecurity Department — *Missouri State University, MO*

- Set up lab environments by resetting and reconfiguring Cisco routers and switches, Palo Alto and FortiGate firewalls, and GNS3 servers
- Built and administer a Dell PowerEdge R730 server running Proxmox, provisioning 15 Windows and Linux VMs supporting multiple ITC lab courses
- Served as red team operator for a graded cybersecurity midterm, scripting staged escalating attacks against 10 hosts defended by 5 students

Resident Assistant — Aug. 2024 – May 2026
Residence Life Housing and Dining Services — *Missouri State University, MO*

- Led and supported 47 residents through consistent engagement, community building, and social programming, resulting in a 70%+ resident reapplication rate
- De-escalated and managed 38 emergencies and high-stress incidents through calm decision-making and conflict resolution
- Resolved WPA2-Enterprise and RADIUS authentication issues for residents connecting personal devices to campus Wi-Fi, reducing escalations to campus IT

Cyber Cubs Camp Counselor — Aug. 2026
Information Technology and Cybersecurity Department — *Missouri State University, MO*

- Authored and delivered a cryptography lesson and hands-on RJ45 cable termination lab for 9 middle school campers in a 17-camper cohort

Competitions

Linux Team Lead — Feb. 2025 – Mar. 2026
Collegiate Cyber Defense Competition (CCDC) — *1st Place Missouri, 7th Place Midwest Region*

- Sustained 90%+ scored service uptime as team lead by directing three engineers across e-commerce, mail, and logging while detecting and remediating intrusions from professional penetration testers
- Kept a customer-facing OpenCart storefront and admin portal online through sustained attack by hardening Apache2, PHP, and MySQL and enforcing host-based firewall rules with iptables and UFW
- Completed 30+ timed business injects on deadline, spanning technical builds and service redundancy through regulatory gap analyses and executive briefings

America's Innovate IT Collegiate Conference (AITCC) — Apr. 2026
2nd Place, IT Troubleshooting; Honorable Mention, Cyber Sentinels Challenge — *Missouri State University, MO*

- Advanced through a written qualifier to a timed finals round, resolving all 10 Linux faults and half of a parallel Windows set across two machines in 60 minutes